Two Days in Bern

A short guide for first-time visitors

Travel Club

Spring 2026

1 Welcome to Bern

Bern is the federal city of Switzerland, but it feels more like a large village than a capital. Its medieval Old Town sits on a narrow hill inside a tight loop of the River Aare, as the map in Figure 1 shows, and it has been a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 1983.

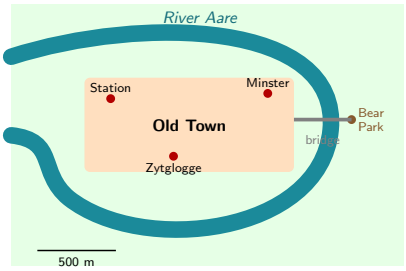


Figure 1: The Old Town inside the loop of the river.

Everything in the centre is within walking distance, and the trams are included in the free guest card that most hotels give to their visitors. Two days are enough to see the main sights at a relaxed pace, with time left for a long lunch and an afternoon by the water. Spring and early autumn are the best seasons, because the city is quieter and the weather is mild enough for walking all day.

2 Day One: The Old Town

Start at the railway station and walk east along the main street. The street is lined with six kilometres of covered arcades, so you can explore even on a rainy day. Figure 2 shows the Old Town from the river.

At the Zytglogge clock tower, arrive a few minutes before the hour to watch the mechanical figures move. Continue to the Minster, whose tower is the tallest in the country, and finish the day at the Bear Park on the other side of the bridge.



Figure 2: The Old Town of Bern seen from the bank of the River Aare.

3 Day Two: Gardens and the River

In summer, local people swim in the **River Aare**. The water is clean but cold and fast, so only strong swimmers should try it, and only at the official places.



Figure 3: Sunflowers at the botanical garden, rotated and at their natural orientation.

If you prefer to stay dry, the botanical garden near the river is free to enter and very quiet in the morning. The flowers in Figure 3 bloom there from July to September.

Remember: most shops close early on Saturday and stay closed on Sunday.

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